

Sideloading an APK on Meta Quest

Sep 26, 2026

Overview

The process has three parts. First you turn on Developer Mode. Then you install the APK from a PC. After that, the game shows up on the headset under **Unknown Sources**. This is called sideloading. It is the normal way to test your own Unity builds on a Quest.

What you need

- A Meta Quest headset (Quest 2, 3, 3S or Pro), charged and updated
- The **Meta Horizon** app on your phone, signed in with the same account as the headset
- A Windows PC or Mac
- A **USB-C data cable**. The cable must carry data, not only charge.
- The game's .apk file, built for Quest (Android, arm64)

Step 1: Turn on Developer Mode

You only need to do this once per headset.

1. On a browser, go to developers.meta.com/horizon and sign in with your Meta account.
2. Create an **organization**. Any name works, for example your studio name.
 - Meta may ask you to verify your account. Usually this is a phone number or a payment method.
3. On your phone, open the **Meta Horizon** app. Go to **Devices** and pick your headset.
4. Open **Headset settings** → **Developer mode** and switch it **on**.
5. Restart the headset: hold the power button, then choose **Restart**.

Step 2: Install the APK from your PC

First connect the headset to the PC and allow access:

1. Plug the headset into the PC with the USB-C data cable.
2. Put the headset on. When the **Allow USB debugging?** prompt appears, tick **Always allow from this computer** and choose **Allow**.

Then install the APK. Any one of these three options works.

Option A: Meta Quest Developer Hub (easiest)

1. Download and install Meta Quest Developer Hub (MQDH) from developers.meta.com/horizon/downloads and sign in.
2. In **Device Manager**, check that your headset shows as connected.
3. Drag the .apk file onto the **Apps** section, or click **Add Build**. Wait until the install finishes.

Option B: SideQuest

1. Install the **SideQuest Advanced Installer** from sidequestvr.com/setup-howto.
2. Look for a green dot at the top left. It means the headset is connected.
3. Click the **Install APK file from folder** icon (the box with a down arrow) and choose your .apk.

Option C: Command line (adb)

```
adb devices
```

```
adb install -r "C:\path\to\game.apk"
```

The first command should list your headset as device. -r replaces an older version of the game if one is already installed.

Using Unity? Go to **File → Build Profiles**, choose **Android**, select the Quest under **Run Device**, then click **Build And Run**. Unity builds the game and installs it in one step.

Step 3: Play the game on the headset

Sideloaded games do not show with your normal apps. They are listed under **Unknown Sources**.

1. Unplug the cable if you like. The game stays installed.
2. Put the headset on and open the **App Library** (the grid icon on the menu bar).
3. Open the filter dropdown at the top right. It usually says **All**. Choose **Unknown Sources**.
4. Select your game to launch it.

To remove the game later, open **Unknown Sources**, click the three dots next to the game, and choose **Uninstall**.

Troubleshooting and safety

Most install problems come from the cable or from a USB prompt that was never accepted.

Problem	Fix
Headset not detected, or shows as unauthorized	Put the headset on and accept Allow USB debugging . Try another cable or another USB port.
No Developer mode option in the phone app	Finish creating the organization and verifying your account (Step 1). Then close and reopen the app.
INSTALL_FAILED_UPDATE_INCOMPATIBLE	An older copy was signed with a different key. Uninstall it first, then install again.
INSTALL_FAILED_OLDER_SDK	The APK needs a newer Android version. Update the headset software.
Game not in the library	Change the App Library filter to Unknown Sources .
Game opens as a flat 2D window	The APK was not built as a VR app. In Unity, enable OpenXR or Oculus under XR Plug-in Management for Android.

Safety: Only install APKs you built yourself or got from a developer you trust. APKs from random sites can contain malware. Pirated games also break Meta's terms, and your account can be banned.